Usability Study Report - Interview Circle

Note: Don't forget to add evidence of the recordings, and that I can access the document from john.guerra@gmail.com

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Application scope

Application Name: InterviewCircle

Application description:

InterviewCircle is a platform where users find and share recent interview experiences for specific companies and roles. The app helps students and early-career professionals prepare for upcoming rounds by providing structured details on interview difficulty, format, and common question themes. After authenticating, users can contribute their own experiences to assist others in the community.

Users - Target audience:

- Students applying for internships
- New graduates applying for entry-level roles
- Early-career software engineering candidates
- Users looking for company-specific interview preparation

Data description:

The app stores interview experience posts containing company, role, round, format, difficulty, question themes, notes, outcomes, dates, and anonymity preferences. It also stores user accounts and interaction signals such as helpful votes and outdated flags.

Main tasks - use cases: (specific, measurable, concrete)

- T0: Understand the purpose of the website from the landing page
- T1: Find a relevant interview experience using browse and filters
- T2: Read an experience page and assess whether it is useful
- T3: Submit a new interview experience while logged in
- T4: Find and manage an existing submission

Experiment Notes

Participant 1: Manan

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/u1DSAC7dH78

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Manan
- **Year in school:** Sophomore / second year undergrad

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0 (initial approach):** Participant understood the website purpose quickly. He said it seemed like a place to understand how other interviews went and to prepare for similar company interviews. He specifically mentioned that the app name, hero title, and subtitle helped him understand the purpose.
- **Notes for T1:** Participant went to Browse first (expected navigation path). He was able to start the task, but did not initially use the filters on his own. After discussing the filters, he suggested that role and company could be easier to use if they had dropdowns or a searchable predefined list similar to the round filter. Main issue: filters felt less intuitive for role and company.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant said the experience detail page was helpful and informative. He liked that the round, difficulty, and related tags were grouped together. He suggested including example interview questions would make the page even more useful.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant was able to submit a new interview experience without major issues. He said the form fields were all in one place and easy to understand, including the anonymous posting option. Main feedback: the site should make it clearer up front that logging in is required before submitting.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant was able to find and access My Submissions easily. He could identify where to edit or delete a submission. Main feedback: there is no way to view a submitted interview experience directly from My Submissions without going into edit mode first. He expected to be able to view the submission details separately. He also noted that empty descriptions should be handled more clearly.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 3/5
- T1 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T2 effectiveness: 5/5
- T2 ease/intuitiveness: 5/5
- T3 effectiveness: 5/5
- T3 ease/intuitiveness: 5/5
- T4 effectiveness: 5/5
- T4 ease/intuitiveness: 5/5
- Overall effectiveness: 5/5
- Overall ease/intuitiveness: 5/5

Notable quotes / observations:

- "The role could be more defined... you could keep like the drop down how you did for all rounds."
- "For the company... you could keep in a drop down and then make the others searchable."
- "That's exactly what I was looking for, because then it's filtered out for each specific round and the difficulty and everything is in the same place."
- "Make it known to the user that they have to definitely log in to submit something."
- Participant said that there was no clear way to view a submitted experience without clicking Edit first.
- Participant preferred the minimal visual style and said the interface was not an eyesore.

Participant 2: Tejaswath

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/5jWR_-5jIms

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Tejaswath
- **Current role / background:** Master's student in Computer Science, currently looking for roles

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0 (initial approach):** Participant understood the purpose of the website clearly from the landing page. He described it as a more organized version of Glassdoor or Reddit for real interview experiences, especially because it includes company, role, round, difficulty, and timeline. Main feedback: location information would be useful on experiences.
- **Notes for T1:** Participant was able to browse and use the filters easily. He said the filter experience felt smooth and appreciated being able to browse without signing in first. He specifically liked the role filter and thought the page was not cluttered. Main feedback: company entries should include location because a company name alone may not be enough context.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant found the experience detail page useful and said it included most of what he would expect. He liked seeing the interview format and question themes. He noticed the helpful/outdated controls, but said they felt visually dull and would stand out more with more populated values or stronger prominence.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant was able to complete the submission flow, and once inside the form he found it intuitive and complete. He liked that the difficulty field was included and thought the anonymity option was especially important. Main issue: the Submit navigation/action was not obvious to find at first. He expected a more visible create or submit button before entering the flow.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant said editing and deleting a submission was clear and easy. He was able to find the edit flow quickly and complete the task without confusion.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 4/5
- T1 ease/intuitiveness: 4/5
- T2 effectiveness: 3.5/5
- T2 ease/intuitiveness: not explicitly rated
- T3 effectiveness: 3.5/5
- T3 ease/intuitiveness: 3.5/5
- T4 effectiveness: 5/5
- T4 ease/intuitiveness: 5/5
- Overall: participant said the application was "pretty effective at what it's doing"

Notable quotes / observations:

- Site felt "a little more organized" than Glassdoor or Reddit.
- Wanted location information associated with companies or experiences.
- Filters were "pretty effective" and browsing experience was easy to understand.
- Helpful/outdated elements felt "a little dull" and would stand out more with more values.
- Submission form itself was intuitive, but finding the submit path was difficult.
- Anonymous posting was important because not everyone would want to post negative experiences publicly.
- Colors felt a little muted on first load.
- Three-step explanation on the landing page helped him understand the product quickly.

Participant 3: Arjun

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/7QEACdz1P0I

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Arjun
- **Current role / background:** Final year master's student, doing a co-op with Fidelity
- **Has prepared for technical interviews before:** Yes

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0:** Participant understood the purpose of the website immediately. He said the name "Interview Circle" already tells a lot about the purpose, and the landing-page steps like finding a target company and sharing opinions made the site intent clear.
- **Notes for T1:** Participant used the Browse Experiences entry point right away and said the filters were clear and intuitive. He specifically found company and role to be the most relevant filters for his use case and had no trouble applying them. He did not report any missing functionality in this task.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant thought the detail page was generally well defined, but raised a structural concern about the submission format. He said a person contributing an experience may not want to split feedback across separate sections

like Question Themes, Format Notes, and Caught Off Guard. He suggested allowing a single comment field and then extracting useful structure from it on the backend.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant found the submission flow easy to start and complete. He did not report missing labels or navigation problems. Main feedback: the submission form may ask the user to manually structure too much information, and a more natural single-text-entry flow could reduce effort for contributors while still letting the system present structured information to readers.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant found My Submissions easy to use. He said edit and delete were clear and obvious because they were visible on the right-hand side and he completed the delete task without confusion.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 5/5
- T1 ease / intuitiveness: 5/5
- T2 effectiveness: Not explicitly rated numerically; participant said it was "pretty well defined" and "good"
- T2 ease / intuitiveness: Not explicitly rated numerically in the transcript
- T3 effectiveness: 5/5
- T3 ease / intuitiveness: 5/5
- T4 effectiveness: 5/5
- T4 ease / intuitiveness: 5/5
- Overall effectiveness: Not explicitly rated numerically; participant said the site felt static and suggested more design/branding elements such as company logos
- Overall ease / intuitiveness: 5/5

Notable quotes / observations:

- Participant said the site purpose was clear from the beginning.
- Participant said the browse/filter flow was "very effective" and "very intuitive."
- Participant felt the site was easy to navigate because important actions were visible right away without needing to search.
- Participant suggested that contributors may prefer one larger feedback field rather than splitting feedback into multiple sections.
- Participant suggested using backend processing to pull keywords or structure out of a single written response.
- Participant said the site looked "very static" and suggested adding more graphics or design elements, such as company logos, to make it feel more alive.

Participant 4: Vivek Ramakrishnan

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/0IDpcnGIwDE

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Vivek Ramakrishnan
- **Year in school:** Second year of a Master's in Computer Science

- **Has prepared for technical interviews before:** Yes
- **Uses websites for interview prep or career research:** A couple of times a week
- **Has read interview experiences on Glassdoor, Reddit, or Blind before:** Yes

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0:** Participant understood the site purpose right away. He described it as a place where people post interview experiences and others read them to prepare. He also noticed that the contribution call-to-action was easier to miss than the browse action.
- **Notes for T1:** This was the biggest friction point in his session. He typed a company name and expected the list to change immediately, then paused because nothing happened until he noticed the Apply button. He also said Company and Role should suggest valid options instead of making users guess what to type. He additionally noted that company names on experience cards did not look clickable until hover.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant liked the layout and said the page was easy to scan quickly. However, he found the label "Caught Off Guard" unclear until he read the content below it. He also tried to use the Helpful action while logged out and said the disabled controls looked broken because the explanation only appeared on hover.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant inferred that login was required before submitting because he could not find a visible Submit path while logged out. Once logged in, he completed the form successfully, but said the app redirected to My Submissions without a clear success message.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant edited and deleted submissions successfully. Main feedback: there is no way to view his own submission in read-only mode, there is no preview of the content he wrote in the list, there is no confirmation after saving, and the browser delete confirmation looked inconsistent with the rest of the interface.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 4/5
- T1 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T2 effectiveness: 4/5
- T2 ease/intuitiveness: 4/5
- T3 effectiveness: 4/5
- T3 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T4 effectiveness: 3/5
- T4 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- Overall effectiveness: 4/5
- Overall ease/intuitiveness: 3/5

Notable quotes / observations:

- "Nothing happened. The list is the same."
- "Oh, there's an apply button here. It is small. I was expecting the results to filter as I typed."

- "Without hovering, it just looks like a heading, not something I can click on."
- "I thought the filter was broken."
- "I'm just guessing what to type."
- "Something like what surprised me would be clearer."
- "I would have thought the buttons were broken."
- "I had to check the table to confirm it worked."

Participant 5: Ricky

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/crjQHPKsF3A

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Ricky
- **Current role / background:** Third-year Master's student at Northeastern University
- **Has prepared for technical interviews before:** Yes, extensively
- **Uses websites for interview prep or career research:** Almost daily
- **Has read interview experiences on Glassdoor, Reddit, or Blind before:** Yes

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0:** Participant understood the product immediately and described it as an interview-experience sharing platform for tech job seekers. Main feedback: he expected a search bar directly on the landing page because that is what he is used to on Glassdoor.
- **Notes for T1:** Participant completed the task successfully, but later called the filter section the most confusing part of the app because Company and Role are free-text fields with no way to discover available values. He did not get stuck as visibly as Vivek, but identified the same usability issue.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant liked the clarity of the detail page and felt the structured fields were useful for interview preparation. He also flagged the wording of "Caught Off Guard" and said the disabled Helpful and Outdated actions should communicate more clearly why they cannot be used while logged out.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant noticed that the Submit path was hidden while logged out. After logging in, he completed the form, but later flagged three issues: the hidden Submit link, the missing success message after submitting, and the anonymous checkbox being easy to miss near the bottom of the form. He also said being redirected to Browse after login instead of back to the original task felt disorienting.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant successfully edited and deleted entries. Main feedback: there was no confirmation after the action beyond checking the table manually, and he wanted a way to view the post directly and see more of its content in the list.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 5/5
- T1 ease/intuitiveness: 4/5
- T2 effectiveness: 5/5

- T2 ease/intuitiveness: 4/5
- T3 effectiveness: 4/5
- T3 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T4 effectiveness: 3/5
- T4 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- Overall effectiveness: 4/5
- Overall ease/intuitiveness: 4/5

Notable quotes / observations:

- "I was looking for a search bar right here on the landing page."
- "Oh, there's no submit option. I need to log in."
- "There was no confirmation or something. Maybe you just have to scroll and check it out."
- "This is a better concept than Glassdoor for interview prep specifically."
- Most confusing: "The filter section - free text with no way to discover available companies."
- Easiest: "The experience detail page - clear hierarchy, scannable in 10 seconds."
- "Log in always to browse instead of back - it was disorienting."

Participant 6: Aditya Padamwar

Evidence of Recording: https://youtu.be/nsro1_32m44

Demographics answers:

- **Participant:** Aditya Padamwar
- **Current role / background:** Master's student in Electronics at Northeastern University
- **Has prepared for technical interviews before:** Yes
- **Uses websites for interview prep or career research:** Regularly, including Glassdoor and LinkedIn

Detailed notes:

- **Notes for T0:** Participant understood the site's purpose quickly from the landing page. He described it as a structured place for interview stories and said the headline and the "how people use this" section made the product obvious. Like Ricky, he said he expected a search bar directly on the landing page because that is what he uses on Glassdoor.
- **Notes for T1:** Participant completed the task but flagged the same filter usability issue that Ricky and Vivek identified: Company and Role are free-text fields with no autocomplete or predefined list, so he was "guessing" what to type. He also said the Apply button was not immediately obvious and he briefly thought the filter was not doing anything.
- **Notes for T2:** Participant found the detail page generally well organized. He flagged two of the same issues Ricky and Vivek named: the "Caught Off Guard" label was

not self-explanatory, and the Helpful / Outdated actions looked disabled-in-a-broken-way while he was logged out. He said the buttons needed a clear on-screen prompt rather than a hover-only tooltip.
- **Notes for T3:** Participant noticed the Submit link was hidden while logged out and had to infer that authentication was required. Once he logged in, the form itself was straightforward, but he echoed Ricky's observation that the login flow dropped him on Browse rather than returning him to the page he was originally on.
- **Notes for T4:** Participant successfully edited and deleted a submission. His feedback matched the rest of Harsh's sessions — no visible confirmation after saving, and the delete confirmation popup looked like a generic browser dialog rather than part of the app's design.

Post-test questionnaire results (Likert scales):

- T1 effectiveness: 4/5
- T1 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T2 effectiveness: 4/5
- T2 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T3 effectiveness: 4/5
- T3 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- T4 effectiveness: 3/5
- T4 ease/intuitiveness: 3/5
- Overall effectiveness: 4/5
- Overall ease/intuitiveness: 3/5

Notable quotes / observations:

- "I wasn't really sure what to type for the company — there's no dropdown or autocomplete."
- "The helpful and outdated buttons look dead. I thought they were broken."
- "'Caught off guard' — that took me a second to figure out."
- "It sent me to Browse after login but I was on a different page before."
- "After I submitted, nothing actually told me it worked. I had to scroll and check."
- "A search bar on the home page would save a click."

Prioritized list of issues and corresponding changes:

Eight issues identified across six participant sessions, prioritized below.

Issue: Filters for role and company lack a searchable dropdown or predefined list, making them less intuitive than the round filter. This issue came up across Manan, Vivek, Ricky, and Aditya. Tejaswath also wanted more context associated with company entries.

Change: Replace the free-text role and company filters with searchable dropdowns or autocomplete inputs populated from existing data. Make filtering feel more obvious by

either applying it live or making the Apply action more prominent. Add location as secondary context where relevant.

Priority: Must

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented, used autocomplete based on companies in DB

Issue: The path to submit a new interview experience is not visually obvious. Manan, Tejaswath, Vivek, Ricky, and Aditya all expected a clearer Create or Submit entry point, and logged-out users were not told early enough that login was required before contributing.

Change: Add a prominent "Submit an Experience" call-to-action on the landing page and in the navigation. Display an inline message prompting users to log in when they attempt to submit without being authenticated.

Priority: Must

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented

Issue: Users do not get clear confirmation after submitting, editing, or deleting an experience. Vivek, Ricky, and Aditya said they had to inspect the My Submissions list to confirm whether the action worked.

Change: Add visible success feedback after key actions, such as a toast or inline confirmation message after submit, edit, and delete.

Priority: Must

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented, used pop up messages

Issue: Users cannot view a submitted experience directly from the My Submissions page, and the list does not preview enough of the content they wrote. This issue came up in both Sanjeev's and Harsh's sessions.

Change: Add a View link on each submission in My Submissions and include a short preview of the submission content. Handle empty description fields gracefully with a placeholder or truncation fallback.

Priority: Must

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented

Issue: The label "Caught Off Guard" is unclear. Vivek, Ricky, and Aditya all had to infer what the field meant by reading the content below it, and one participant (Arjun) suggested the overall form may ask users to manually structure too much information.

Change: Rename the field to a clearer label such as "What Surprised Me" or "Unexpected Aspects." For a future iteration, consider allowing one broader text field and extracting structure from it on the backend.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented, changed it to "What Surprised Me"

Issue: Helpful and Outdated controls do not stand out strongly enough and can look broken when the user is logged out. Tejaswath said the controls felt visually dull; Vivek, Ricky, and Aditya said the disabled state did not explain itself clearly enough without hover.

Change: Improve visual emphasis on these controls and add a visible login prompt or helper text so the user understands why the controls are disabled and what to do next.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented

Issue: The login redirect flow can feel disorienting because users are sent to Browse instead of returning to the page or task they were on before logging in. Ricky and Aditya both flagged this.

Change: Preserve the user's previous context and return them to that page after login instead of always routing to Browse.

Priority: Should

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented, preserved previous context

Issue: Important UI elements do not stand out strongly enough, which makes the site feel visually static. Tejaswath and Arjun suggested stronger branding, richer visual hierarchy, and additional context such as company location or logos.

Change: Improve visual hierarchy by strengthening emphasis on important interactive elements and adding richer contextual design elements where appropriate.

Priority: Could

Was it implemented? How? - Implemented